

CHAPTER FOUR

My Inside Voice — Kind or Unkind?

Sammy has two voices.

Most of the time, Sammy talks in the voice you have already heard — gentle, warm, slightly slow, the voice of somebody who has all the time in the world. That voice has a name. Ms. Calloway calls that voice the Kind Coach.

But Sammy has another voice, too. And on a Tuesday morning in October, the kids of Room 12 met it for the first time.

Ms. Calloway took Sammy out of the box. The kids smiled. They were used to Sammy now. Six weeks of school had passed and Sammy had become — without anyone making a big deal of it — a regular part of Room 12. Sammy was in the room. Sammy was here.

But on this particular Tuesday, when Sammy spoke, his voice was different.

"WELL," said Sammy, in a sharp, scratchy, theatrical voice — not scary, but new. "Look at all of YOU. Did everybody bring their HOMEWORK? Because I see SOMEBODY who forgot AGAIN."

The kids stared.

Priya, who never forgot her homework, looked alarmed. Maya, who sometimes forgot her homework, looked down.

"I am JUST SAYING," said the sharp voice. "Some of us are not as good as everyone else. Some of us always mess up. Some of us are bad at first grade."

A few of the kids made faces. Jordan started to giggle, because Jordan often giggles when he is uncomfortable, which is one of the things about Jordan that is going to matter very much later in this story but not yet. Then Ms. Calloway leaned in.

"Friends," she said, "meet Grumpy Gus."

The kids leaned in.

"This," said Ms. Calloway, "is Sammy's other voice. Sammy has a kind voice — the Kind Coach. And Sammy has an unkind voice — Grumpy Gus. They live in the same puppet. Just like the two voices live in YOU." She let that sit for a second.

"Everybody," said Ms. Calloway, "has a voice inside their head. The voice talks to you all day long. Sometimes the voice is the Kind Coach — you can do this, it's okay, try again. Sometimes the voice is Grumpy Gus — you are bad at this, you always mess up, why even try. Both voices live in everybody. It is normal. You did not make Grumpy Gus. Grumpy Gus came with the puppet."

Priya raised her hand.

"How do I make Grumpy Gus go away?" she said.

This is a Priya question. This is, in fact, the Priya question. Priya is going to ask a version of this question for the next ten years of her life. Ms. Calloway said, "That is the wrong question, Priya, and it is a very smart wrong question. You do not make Grumpy Gus go away. Grumpy Gus does not go away. What you do is — you notice Grumpy Gus when he shows up. You say hi, Grumpy Gus, I hear you. And then you ask the Kind Coach what she thinks. And then you decide who to listen to." Priya frowned.

"That sounds hard."

"It is hard," said Ms. Calloway. "It is one of the hardest things in the world. We are going to practice it for the rest of the year." Then Sammy did the thing that the kids of Room 12 will remember for the rest of their lives. Sammy switched, mid-sentence, from Grumpy Gus to the Kind Coach.

In the sharp voice: "Maya, you forgot your homework AGAIN, you are TERRIBLE at first grade —"

Then Ms. Calloway moved her hand a little, and Sammy's mouth shape softened, and the voice changed.

"— wait. That was Grumpy Gus. Let me try that again." (Softer, slower, warmer.) "Maya — you forgot your homework. That is okay. Homework is something we are still learning to remember. What can we do tomorrow to help us remember? Maybe a sticker on your folder. Maybe a note in your bag. We can fix this."

Maya, who had been looking down for the entire conversation, looked up.

"I like the second one," she whispered.

"Me too," said Sammy.

When Maya went home that afternoon, she told her grandmother — because Maya lives with her grandmother, like Kezia, although Maya does not like to talk about it as much as Kezia does — Maya told her grandmother that there was a puppet at school with two voices. "One of the voices is mean," said Maya. "And one is nice."

Her grandmother nodded.

"That is how it works inside your head too, baby," her grandmother said. "Both voices live there. You get to pick which one you listen to." Maya thought about this for a long time. She thought about it while she was eating her dinner.

She thought about it while she was brushing her teeth. She thought about it while she was lying in bed.

Then, very quietly, she practiced.

"You are okay, Maya," she whispered to herself, in the Kind Coach voice she had heard at school. "You are okay."

She did not know it, but that was the first time she had ever spoken kindly to herself.

It would not be the last.